

Why do people try to convince each other that using AI is the worst thing for the environment ?

Posted by u/evphsu • 0 points • 19 comments

In my mind, average people using ai all day gets cancelled out by 1 rich guy taking his jet for dinner. But I don't actually know how true that is. As an American, things have been pretty confusing I guess.

I'm just wondering if this opinion of mine is just me being propagandized against "The Man" and having conspiracy brain in light of all the news but it just seems like this is another one of those things that's implanted by the corporate powers that be to keep us fighting with each other.

Comments

u/The_True_Hannatude • 1 points • 2026-02-22 13:17 UTC

It shouldn't be "Rich People do Terrible Thing X, which is worse than our collective Bad Thing Y, so I'm going to keep doing Bad Thing Y."

Because yes, many Rich People do Terrible Thing X, and there's nothing any of us, as individuals, can do to change that. (Nothing legal, anyway)

But we *do* have the ability to say, "Terrible Thing X doesn't negate Bad Thing Y, it only adds to it, so I choose *not* to do Bad Thing Y, and neither should you."

To put it in a more tangible way: Finding old appliances someone tossed out in the woods to avoid disposal fees doesn't make throwing food wrappers on the ground acceptable.

The fridge being there is a problem, yes, and there's nothing you can do to stop the coolant that's leaked out all over the ground.

But you can keep your trash from joining it by choosing to stick it in your pocket until you find a garbage can.

u/DeliciousEstate3983 • 2 points • 2026-02-22 13:07 UTC

I understand what you mean and we should be nuanced, but the thing is a billionaire may ride in a jet 100 times and that will have less of an effect on the people's day to day life than a AI data center, countless amounts of water used, countless amounts of energy being stolen from homes, and most importantly and unfortunately the air and noise pollution

They have flown drones over AI data centers and realized they're hosting huge illegal chemical gas releases, meaning huge clouds ate leaving noticeable traces of toxic chemicals directly into the air and soil, causing damage toneurological, growth and lung health

They also did sound pollution scans, they found out people who lived next to AI data centers even within months of living next to them reported a major uptick in hearing loss checkups and chronic migraine/headache issues, that is the least of issues because due to the 24/7 machinery the vibrations have been proven to cause long term neurological damage

Every time you use AI your another number on a shady city investors spreadsheet on why they should build a megasized ai data center next to a kindergarden

u/Beneficial-War5423 • 2 points • 2026-02-22 12:58 UTC

Well there isn't that much billionaire using their jet to get breakfast.

And using AI all day isn't really worst than eating a steak.

The thing is we want to reduce our impact on the environment not augment it.

It would be a good idea to stop eating steak (or consuming less in a more general way) and AI aim at producing more.

But I think we should start by enforce regulations that correlate price to environmental impact. If IA was more expensive we would use it when we need it and it would be more acceptable

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2026-02-22 12:56 UTC

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u/Bandro • 5 points • 2026-02-22 12:48 UTC

One person's environmental impact is dwarfed by some rich person's private jet. Everyone's small but shitty impact far, far outweighs that rich person's private jet.

u/THEbassettMAN • 2 points • 2026-02-22 12:46 UTC

I think the larger issue is the lack of necessity of AI usage. If what you use AI for results in a lot of low quality slop or just replicates something you could have easily done with some other available, non-AI tool (or even by yourself if you put a little effort in), that's going to strike people as being more wasteful than rich people doing regular rich people shit. It's more viable for a normal person to write their

own email without ChatGPT than it is for Bill Gates to paddle a kayak to the Epstein Island Annual BBQ, so a normal person opting to instead turn to a bot feels like the lazier choice.

u/Flowmielli • 2 points • 2026-02-22 12:43 UTC

<https://earth.org/the-green-dilemma-can-ai-fulfil-its-potential-without-harming-the-environment/>

<https://elm.umaryland.edu/elm-stories/2025/Environmental-Considerations-for-Using-AI.php>

<https://yaleclimateconnections.org/2025/09/what-you-need-to-know-about-ai-and-climate-change/>

And if you dont like reading here's videos

<https://youtu.be/SkWzwoDIGmE?si=-mTujC6c23EGRlkr>

<https://youtube.com/shorts/P65St7anMz0?si=uuU2-XEpQDJmyRRX>

<https://youtu.be/fgrVXraE5Mg?si=bTk3ZaLrNC6Du5dZ>

u/punkwhohatespunk • 2 points • 2026-02-22 12:41 UTC

People who realize what it's going to eventually do are doing what they can to slow this down. They don't know it's too late.

u/Petwins • 3 points • 2026-02-22 12:36 UTC

The worst thing or a consistently bad thing for minimal positive impact?

No the ai impact by volume is orders of magnitude above a private jet flight.

Even if it somehow wasn't, so what? It doesn't make the impact of the ai usage go away, and its still a bad thing to be mitigated even if there are worse things also out there. Things in other contexts being worse is not in anyway a reason to ignore a bad thing.

For your second paragraph I think you are just under the impression that it stops people from caring about other topics for some reason and thats not the case. The idea that you can only focus on big things is something groups push to get you to ignore practically addressable issues that impact bigger corporations.

u/evphsu • 1 points • 2026-02-22 12:38 UTC

Thanks for the thoughtful response

u/VexoriaNa • 1 points • 2026-02-22 12:36 UTC

Data centers gulp water

u/EctoplasmicNeko • 0 points • 2026-02-22 12:41 UTC

Behold, the rest of industry.

u/Zealousideal-Fun3917 • 2 points • 2026-02-22 12:55 UTC

<https://www.asce.org/publications-and-news/civil-engineering-source/article/2024/09/17/america-is-in-a-water-crisis-but-help-is-on-the-way>

u/EctoplasmicNeko • 0 points • 2026-02-22 12:58 UTC

Ok, fair, but it does seem to me that people then ought be asking some questions of other industries.

u/Zealousideal-Fun3917 • 2 points • 2026-02-22 13:03 UTC

Yes, until those other industries are addressed, it's idiocy to plow ahead with this much worse industry (AI).

u/EctoplasmicNeko • 1 points • 2026-02-22 13:12 UTC

From the figures I've seen AI doesn't register that significantly in water consumption. It's a decent amount, but there are a lot of industries using more. It's simply incorrect to say AI is 'much worse' when it's only a minor player compared to others.

u/Zealousideal-Fun3917 • 1 points • 2026-02-22 13:58 UTC

Those other industries produce physical things. What does AI produce?

u/EctoplasmicNeko • 1 points • 2026-02-22 14:09 UTC

Moving the goal posts are we? Very well.

Taken as it is and utilized properly, AI is broadly

applicable.
Code, Data
processing,
research
and
technical
development
alongside a
whole host
of other
things. It's
not
producing
physical
product, but
it's
enhancing
capability
and
productivity
in a variety
of other
sectors
which are
themselves
producing
product or
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u/Trinelox • 4 points • 2026-02-22 12:35 UTC

Energy use is massive